The Buffer Strategy

A night out should cost you the night.

Not the week, and not the two days after it. This is how you plan one.

01 Decide the number

02 The day itself

03 Spend it where it counts

04 The hour after the last drink

05 The morning after

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WHAT ALCOHOL ACTUALLY DOES

Nothing gets banned here. It gets placed.

Most guys think the belly comes from the calories in the pints. There´s more to it than that.

Alcohol carries almost twice the calories of protein per gram, and none of it fills you up. Five pints is roughly a dinner you did not eat, sitting on top of the dinner you did.

Your body has nowhere to store it, so it goes to the front of the queue. While alcohol is being cleared, fat burning drops down the list. Studies show a couple of drinks can suppress fat oxidation by around a third for several hours.

That does not mean your dinner turns into belly fat. What it means is that the fat you eat around the drinking is the part most likely to be spared and stored, because your system is busy with something else. That is why one specific change on the day makes a difference, and it is not the one most lads try.

It knocks back muscle repair for the night. Eating protein afterwards helps, but it does not fully rescue it.

It does not help you sleep. It knocks you out quickly and then wrecks the second half of the night. That is why the following day feels the way it does.

> THE REAL COST
>
> For most guys it is none of the above. It is the food that comes after the drink, and it is the two flat days that follow. One unplanned night out regularly costs two days of steps, sleep and sessions. That is where a month gets undone.
>
> *So the job is small: decide the number, spend it where it counts, and protect the hour after the last drink.*

01

Decide the number

Set it in the afternoon, when you are sober, not at the bar after the first pint! A number decided in advance holds. A number decided at eleven o'clock is not a number, it is a hope.

800 calories is a workable night for most men. Page three shows exactly what that buys. Some nights will be more and that is fine, as long as you chose it.

— Put a finish time on it as well as a number. The last hour is rarely the good one.

— Pick your nights rather than letting them pick you. Two planned beats four accidental.

— Say it to someone. One of the lads, your wife, the group. A number you have told somebody is a different number.

02

The day itself

Land your protein before you go, not after

Get most of your daily protein number in across breakfast and lunch, and eat a proper protein-led meal before you head out. This is the highest-value thing you can do. A guy who arrives fed makes different decisions at every point of the night.

Keep the fat low on the day

Not zero, just light. No fry, go easy on the oil, the cheese, the nuts and the dressings. This is the one genuine dietary lever on a drinking day, because fat is the macronutrient most likely to be stored while your body is dealing with the alcohol.

Train in the morning if you can

Be straight about why. It does not create room for the drink and it will not cancel the night out. What it does is bank the win before the evening, protect the structure of the day, and make it far less likely you write the whole weekend off.

> ONE THING TO DROP
>
> Do not skip meals to save calories for the night. It is the most common plan and the worst one. You arrive starving, you drink faster on an empty stomach, and every decision after that is a poor one.

03

Spend it where it counts

Approximate figures, Irish measures.

THE DRINK	ROUGHLY	800 BUYS YOU
Vodka or gin, single, soda or slimline	80	10 drinks
Gin, single, regular tonic	130	6 drinks
Spirit, single, full-sugar mixer	170	4-5 drinks
Guinness, pint	210	3.8 pints
Standard lager, pint	200-240	3.5 pints
Craft IPA, 6%, pint	300	2.5 pints
Wine, 175ml glass	160	5 glasses

3 rules that do the work

— **Slimline means slimline.** Regular tonic adds roughly 50 calories to every single drink, all night.

— **Buy volume.** Tall glass, long mixer, plenty of ice. A long night needs something in your hand, and this is how you get it cheaply.

— **Water between rounds.** Not for hydration heroics. It slows the rate and keeps your hand busy.

A MYTH WORTH KILLING

Dry wine and spirits are not sugary. The calories are the alcohol itself. Sugar is a mixer problem, not a drink problem, which is why the fix is the tonic and not the gin.

04

The hour after the last drink

This is where the night is won or lost, and it has almost nothing to do with willpower.

By that point your judgement about food is gone, your appetite signalling is off, and you are standing in front of whatever happens to still be open.

Decide it in the afternoon, same as the number

- **Either:** I am not eating after. Water, bed.
- **Or:** if you know yourself and you know you will eat, decide what, now. Chicken and rice. A proper order rather than whatever is in front of you at closing.

05

The morning after

- **Anchor the first meal.** Protein and fibre. Eggs, yogurt, whatever is quickest.
- **Get outside and walk.** Twenty minutes. It does more for how you feel than anything else available to you.
- **Plan today's food before you are in the middle of today.** Your sleep was poor, which means hunger is up and judgement is down. That is physiology, not weakness.

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